

A SELECTION OF SHORT PIECES

The Door Was Open

Sugar

I remember quite vividly the time my father told me about his youth, when he used to walk into his neighbor's house. I was shocked and asked, "Did you knock on the door?" He replied, "No, I didn't need to. The door was always open." I asked, "Why did you go in?" He said, "We needed sugar, so I took some from there." I stood there in disbelief, scratching my head and looking left and right.

I said with great confusion, "Did you ask for permission first?" He laughed and replied, "No, I didn't need to." He looked at me and smiled, and I smiled back. He then said, "Those times don't exist anymore. We lock our doors and draw our curtains, but back then, your house was my house. We were a family, and we all felt safe."

The First Prayer

I was probably 16 when I first tried to pray. I had no idea what I was doing. It was confusing, embarrassing, but also strangely familiar. Want to know the funny part? I was praying wrong for almost a year. Everything was mixed up. And guess what else? I was facing the wrong direction. I got so upset and almost gave up, but then someone close to me said, “It’s okay to be a beginner.” So, if you’re a beginner like me, remember, it’s okay. You don’t need to be perfect. With time, we’ll improve.

A Door

A few years ago I told a wise spiritual man that the door to God’s vast and beautiful mercy was open. His mouth formed a subtle curve to the right. I was a little confused. I asked him, “Why are you smiling?” He turned and said, “What makes you think there’s a door?”

Come As You Are

I remember traveling to Morocco and meeting a group of saintly old men. I was with a lovely English man who had not yet embraced Islam. He was a skater, so he had a specific type of fashion sense—ripped jeans, earrings, and cool skater drip. We both walked into a beautiful spiritual center, where we were greeted with so much affection and care by the saintly old men.

What struck me most was the smile on my English friend’s face. Not a single person made a comment about his dress, his tattoos, or anything else. These beautiful old men accepted him as he was and looked beyond his appearance.

They didn't care about the clothes he wore; they just cared about him as a person.

He drank lots of mint tea, laughed, and was hugged many times before we left. I asked him, "How did you find that?" He smiled, took a sigh, and said, "I've never experienced that much love in my life." I almost broke down in tears because I realized in that moment that he had just witnessed true Islam. True Islam is a unifying force. It's loving and brings out the best in people.

For me, this is Islam—a religion where you can come as you are, with your brokenness, your habits, and your entire experience, and still find space. Those saintly old men didn't see his appearance; they saw his heart, and they knew that his heart belonged to God, so they treated it with delicate care.

An Invitation to Iftar

A convert sister shared the ache of fasting alone this Ramadan—a pain too familiar for many of our convert brothers and sisters. Ramadan is meant to nourish the soul, not weigh it down with loneliness. If you know a convert who's fasting, reach out. Speak kindness into their heart. Hold space for their struggle. If your bond allows, invite them for Iftar. They left behind so much for this faith. We must be the warmth that welcomes them home.

Bread in the Mountains

I remember seeing a distressed elderly lady in Morocco. She lived in the mountains. I don't know where. But it was remote. She was crying. She held her face in her hands. We spotted her from further up the road and decided to give her some bread that we happened to be gifted earlier on. Bread in Morocco is a huge circular loaf. It is also seen as a spiritual manifestation of God's immense grace.

When she saw that we had given it to her she started crying even more. We stood there a little confused so I decided to ask what was wrong. She told us that her son had just died. She told us that only he looked after her. She said that she had no money for her electricity bill. She looked up to the sky and said she had been begging God for help and that this bread was a sign.

It was a sign that God had not deserted her, and that she would be okay. One of the brothers with me decided to pay an entire month's electricity bill for her. That is when things got really intense. She sat there in a spiritual ecstasy and said, "Oh my Lord! How wonderful you are! Here I am asking you, begging you, seeking your help and here you have sent me Your support. My sustenance was destined to be delivered by strangers who live many many miles away from me! How can we despair? How can we despair when you have indeed promised that you are generous!"

She said that the entire moment was a miracle and an Ayah. Ayah here means a sign, a sign that God is indeed what He promises himself to be—Al Kareem; The Most Generous. It is a moment that will forever continue to shock and amaze me.

She reminded us that everything would ultimately be okay. She was short with rosy cheeks and looked like the grandmother you would look to for comfort.

Together

I am guessing it is safe to say we're all trying to hold hope. We're all riding, betting, leaning on hope. It's what brings us together. It's why we try to smile after sighing. We may never say it loud to each other, but we are all holding onto this huge rope of hope.

Together.